



REDFERNS

ICONIC MOTIF
(Left) A portrait of French Empress Joséphine (1809) shows her in a dress made of a shawl with a paisley border; Mick Jagger wearing a paisley jacket

BOOKS

Never Out of STYLE

BESIDES TRACING THE EVOLUTION OF INDIAN DESIGN AND FASHION, TWO NEW COFFEE TABLE BOOKS SHOW US WHY THEIR EXPORT HAS BEEN CRUCIAL



In October 1686, Claude Le Peletier, Louis XIV's financial controller, banned the import of Indian textiles to France. At about the same time, the East India Company's flooding of Indian cotton to England brought about the collapse of the wool-weaving industry. The craze for chintz was so pervasive that Daniel Defoe (author of *Robinson Crusoe*) lamented that "from foot-cloth to the petticoat...our closets, curtains, cushions, chairs, and at last our beds themselves were nothing but calicos".

Chintz, of course, is a word of Indian origin. But, as Phyllida Jay points out, so are calico, bandanna, muslin, seersucker, shawl, dungarees, madras check, pyjama and khaki, evidence of India's dominance in the rag trade's age-old history.

Jay is a trained anthropologist with an ability to gather innumerable strands of social, political and cultural disruption and weave them into compelling narratives. She is ably supported by her photo editor Priya Kapoor whose assiduous research in museums and design ateliers of the world raise this book's visual and design profile way above a commonplace coffee table ornament (though it is indubitably that).

"India" and "Global Design" being vast, unwieldy expressions, Jay narrows her focus to a handful of chapters that encapsulate 300 years of cross-cultural exchange. From dipping into Edward Said's critique of western perceptions of the Orient to how the sale of a Kashmir shawl saves an indigent boy's future in Thackeray's *Vanity Fair*, robust argument and telling detail give every section a keen savour.





ELEGANT EXPORT
(Top) In *Breakfast at Tiffany's* (1961), Audrey Hepburn wears a sari in the party scene; a Balenciaga gold sari-gown worn by Elizabeth Taylor (1964)